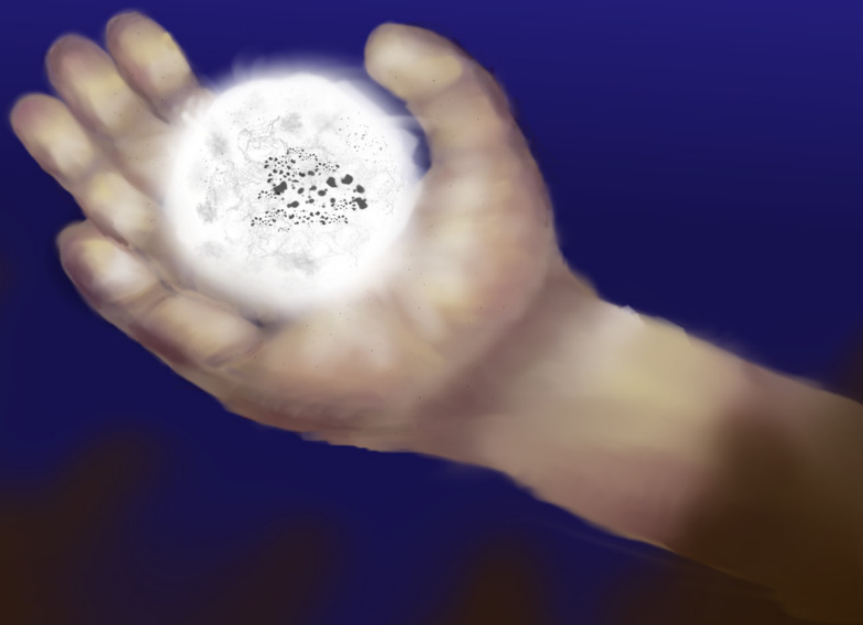




Prologue

A mind incapable of being reprogrammed is a vulnerable one. But you are never more vulnerable when you are being reprogrammed! Whether this is self-inflicted or is done so by your environment is of little consequence. After you're in a more stable state, can you more closely represent what reality is?

Ether's Bicentennial address 2247

The sun burned brightly even though it was an early spring day. In particular it seemed the rays of light had chosen a particular person that day, casually sitting on a bench in a small park. Perhaps it was the fact that he stood out particularly against the background. The brightest of green colors around him, against his casual black outfit which blended well with his skin. He remembered not exactly how he got there... by the time he became aware of himself, it seemed an age of the universe had gone by.

Something gravitated him towards where he was now, though that too he couldn't recall. The only thing he could remember was the constant state of day, and the stories of others playing out in front of him.

He could imagine the construction of the park, whilst he sat there in its center. - He had seen it being built after all - People coming and going all throughout that long day.

Most were children, whose entire histories were being shaped within the park. Friendships born and die. The occasional fight had caused as much. Some groups larger than others. Even a pair, seemingly sisters, one younger than the other, were playing in one corner of the park.

Nothing struck him particularly about any of the groups, of course the children didn't know who he was anyway. The occasional student wondered in the park, a few of them close

to that sisterly pair. But they didn't seem to notice him either.

Until at one point, he knew not what caused it, the elder of the sisters seemed to take the hand of one of those students. Together they explored the park. And naturally, they ended up where he was sitting.

The child tugged at his knee.

"Mister, mister"

The student quickly took her hand away and said "I'm sorry professor. She's a little eager this one."

He smiled. And slowly turned towards the girl. "What is it, little one?"

It seemed like her original courage dissappeared at the student's comment as she quickly grabbed the leg of the student in shame.

A quick laugh also came across the student's face. "She wants to know"

CHAPTER

First Day

[I] was sixteen and already bored of the assembly before it started.

His mother — mom — had dropped him and his sister at the gate without a word, which was not like her.

[IA] found him by the lockers. "Your sister okay? She looked like she'd seen a ghost."

He shrugged it off. He was good at shrugging things off — better than he was at being right about them.

CHAPTER

The Lecture

[II] had taken the professor's course three times now in different

forms, and never seen the slide that went up that morning.

It was not on the syllabus. It was, as far as she could tell, not on anyone's syllabus.

The visiting lecturer introduced himself only as [S].

CHAPTER

The Message

That night [I] logged on and [IB] was already typing.
He stared at the message for a long time.